



UNCC assistant professor Rob Bierregaard releases an osprey back into the wild Tuesday at the Clariant plant in Mecklenburg after it is tagged with a satellite transmitter to track its migratory patterns.

NORMAN NG - STAFF PHOTOS

Worldwide watching possible with osprey transmitter, Web



The transmitter mounted on the back of this osprey can be tracked anywhere in the world. The \$10,000 price tag includes the price of the transmitter itself and the use of satellite time to track the migration of the birds.

Carolina Raptor Center to track bird's migration to unknown winter home

By BRUCE HENDERSON
Staff Writer

A female osprey defending her nest angled out of the sky Tuesday and onto the Internet.

Her shrill cries - tewp tewp tewp teeltee teeltee - quieted as the osprey tangled in a nearly invisible net around a tethered great horned owl posing as an attacker.

After a heart-thumping hour, the osprey and a \$10,000 radio transmitter now strapped to her back were flapping over the Catawba River.

This fall, when she begins her long journey south, we can go, too.

The osprey's migration will be tracked, by way of satellite, on the Carolina Raptor Center's Web site. So will her return to Charlotte next spring, and for as long as both bird and her solar-powered trans-

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Industrial panel member criticized

Dianne Sellers accused of siding with employers, against workers

By MARK JOHNSON
Raleigh Bureau

RALEIGH — A campaign is escalating around a political office that makes decisions affecting hundreds of workers, major corporations and millions of dollars, but a job few people outside state offices in Raleigh have heard of.

Letters, e-mails and phone calls endorsing and criticizing Dianne Sellers, a member of the N.C. Industrial Commission, have streamed into Gov. Mike Easley's office in recent weeks. The barrage has led him to delay a decision about reappointing Sellers.

Labor lawyers, meanwhile, sling statistics they contend show she routinely sides with employers and against workers.

Such lobbying and political assault is rare for such an innocuous appointment. State government veterans can recall only one similar instance in the

past decade.

At the center of the controversy sits Sellers, a 22-year veteran of the Industrial Commission who rose from a deputy commissioner, circuit-riding the state to hear insurance disputes, to chief deputy to full-fledged commissioner in 1994. The squabble over her seat affirms the peculiar politics of a commission designed by law to have opposing sides representing workers and employers.

"When you have not been in the political world, it's all strange" to be the subject of a campaign, said Sellers, a 52-year-old lawyer who has spent virtually her entire professional life at the agency.

Labor lawyers from across the state have organized a lobbying effort to block Sellers' possible reappointment. The relative obscurity of the commission, which hears workers' compensation insurance claims, has done little to diminish the crusade's bitterness.

"It appears to me this individual cannot be fair," said George Lennon, a Raleigh lawyer who represents employees before the commission.

Rick Lewis, a lawyer for insurers and employers, said Sellers' critics want a "cookie cutter" commissioner to join those who regularly side with em-

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Sellers

Quick Takes

Husband charged in wife's death

ROWAN | 2B SALISBURY — Hospital personnel became suspicious Saturday when Michael Ray Logan Sr. changed his story about how his wife was severely injured, police said.

Logan first told doctors that his wife, Annie Logan, slipped on some stairs, but later said she fell in the kitchen. After investigating, police charged Michael Logan with killing his wife.

Doctors determined that Annie Logan, 49, had suffered a cerebral hemorrhage; she never regained consciousness before she died late Saturday night.

Bruton Smith donates \$5 million to school



CHARLOTTE | 2B Charlotte Country Day School received the largest donation in its history Tuesday for construction of the school's new athletic complex. The \$5 million donation was from Speedway Motorsports Inc. founder and Chairman Bruton Smith, whose three sons graduated from the school.

Worldwide watching of osprey on Web is possible

Migrate *from 1B*

mitter survive.

The raptor center and Bruns Avenue Elementary School are partners on the project, with backing from the Cultural Education Collaborative.

The travels of osprey No. 245 should be educational computer fare. The biologists who caught her, Rob Bierregaard of UNC Charlotte and Mark Martell of the University of Minnesota's Raptor Center, say it's a step toward unraveling migration.

Ospreys make accommodating subjects. Once hammered by the

pesticide DDT, the fish-eaters with the 5-foot wingspan are rebounding largely because of man-made nesting platforms.

Tuesday's capture took place at Clariant Corp.'s dye-making plant on the Catawba northwest of Charlotte. Several platforms dot the 1,500-acre campus.

"For many years, if you saw a bird down there you were lucky," said plant manager Dan Truman. "Today you can go down there and see six or eight."

As familiar as ospreys are becoming on the Catawba, researchers have few clues to where the birds go in winter. Most from the Atlantic coast, south of Maine, are believed to migrate to the Carib-

bean and South America.

Radio "tags," applied to birds only in recent years, offer new insights on migration routes, where the birds stop to feed, how fast they fly and what weather patterns trigger flight.

"It gives us a real window on what needs to be conserved in terms of migration and wintering grounds," Martell said.

The Minnesota center has placed transmitters on 130 ospreys and coordinates satellite tracking for the Carolina Raptor Center Web site.

A male osprey that Bierregaard and Martell tagged on Martha's Vineyard, Mass., last summer flew 3,400 miles in 34 days to Ven-

ezuela. The bird's mate took a different route, to the Pacific, but died in Panama.

Half a continent away, busy with her chicks, No. 245 settles atop her telephone pole. She's expected to take wing in September.

Bruce Henderson: (704) 358-5051;
bhenderson@charlotteobserver.com

TRACKING THE BIRDS

The Carolina Raptor Center Web site, which will start tracking the osprey next week, is www.birdsofprey.org. The University of Minnesota's Raptor Center is at www.raptor.cvm.umn.edu.